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Loneliness and Support for Political Violence in the United States

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Abstract: Although loneliness is a growing public health issue in the United States, its political effects remain understudied. Using data from the Chapman Survey of American Fears (Wave 11), this study evaluates whether loneliness predicts support for political violence. Results contradict expectations: loneliness does not increase support for political violence and, instead, reduces willingness to damage property for a political cause. Younger adults (18–34) show the strongest support for political violence regardless of loneliness level, while partisanship is not significant once demographic controls are included. These findings challenge assumptions that lonely people are more prone to extremism and suggest political violence attitudes stem from generational and cultural forces rather than psychosocial distress.

Introduction:

Loneliness is associated with depression, anxiety, weakened immunity, and early mortality, but its political consequences remain understudied. In recent years, the United States has experienced rising threats against political officials, growing polarization, and increased acceptance of political violence. Because loneliness influences social cognition, emotional regulation, and threat processing, scholars theorize that it may shape political behavior. This project investigates whether loneliness predicts support for political violence and whether age or partisanship condition this relationship.

Literature Review:

- Loneliness is a subjective psychological state, not simply the absence of social interaction.
- It heightens vigilance toward social threat, promotes cognitive biases, and affects emotional processing.
- Competing theories:
  - Loneliness → increased aggression due to frustration
  - Loneliness → political withdrawal, not action
- Younger adults show the highest national loneliness levels and heightened political dissatisfaction.
- Partisanship acts as a social identity, but lonely individuals may disengage from partisan groups.

Theoretical expectations: loneliness ↑ violence support; partisanship ↑ violence support; young adults more reactive.

Discussion/Conclusion:

These findings contradict theories linking loneliness to aggression or extremism. Loneliness instead appears connected to political withdrawal and lower willingness to engage in risky activism. Younger adults' higher support for political violence likely stems from political distrust, social frustration, and digital-era socialization—not loneliness. Loneliness does not drive support for political violence. Age is the strongest predictor of political violence attitudes. Future research should distinguish loneliness from online isolation and explore whether ideological extremity moderates the relationship between psychosocial distress and political aggression.

Data and Methodology:

Dataset: Chapman Survey of American Fears (Wave 11; N ≈ 1,015).

Key Measures:

- Loneliness: 3-item UCLA Loneliness Scale (0–3 average).
- Political Violence Attitudes:
  - "Violence is sometimes necessary to advance political goals."
  - "Willing to damage property for a political cause."
- Demographics: age 18–34 vs 35+, gender, race, education, income.
- Partisanship: major-party identifier vs. independent/other.
- Religiosity: frequency of religious attendance.

Statistical Method:

Two logistic regression models predicting each violence outcome.

Model 1: loneliness + partisanship + demographic controls

Model 2: Loneliness × Age interaction

Predicted probabilities were computed for loneliness across age groups.

Regression Results:

Logistic Regression Predicting Agreement That Violence is Sometimes Necessary

Predictor	Coefficient	Std Error	p-value
Intercept	-2.112	0.541	<.001
Loneliness Index	0.486	0.586	.405
Age 18–34	1.431	0.387	<.001
Female	-0.921	0.324	.004
White	0.618	0.331	.062
Education	-0.153	0.093	.099
Income	-0.058	0.082	.484
Religious Attendance	-0.131	0.048	.006
Major-Party ID	0.454	0.301	.131

Logistic Regression Predicting Willingness to Damage Property

Predictor	Coefficient	Std Error	p-value
Intercept	-1.762	0.462	<.001
Loneliness Index	-1.284	0.587	.028
Age 18–34	0.986	0.333	.003
Female	-0.642	0.287	.026
White	-0.117	0.297	.696
Education	-0.084	0.085	.327
Income	-0.071	0.074	.331
Religious Attendance	-0.142	0.045	.002
Major-Party ID	0.384	0.283	.175

Final Results:

- Loneliness does not predict support for political violence.
- Loneliness reduces willingness to damage property.
- Younger adults show the highest support for political violence across all models.
- Partisanship is not significant once controls are included.
- The Loneliness × Age interaction is not supported.

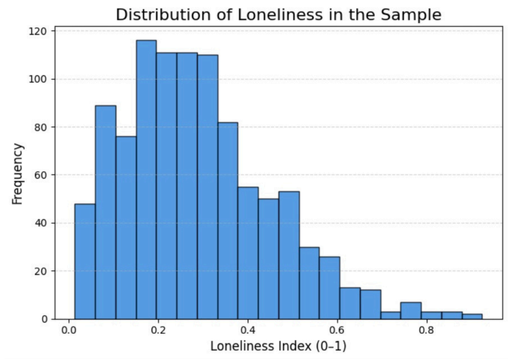
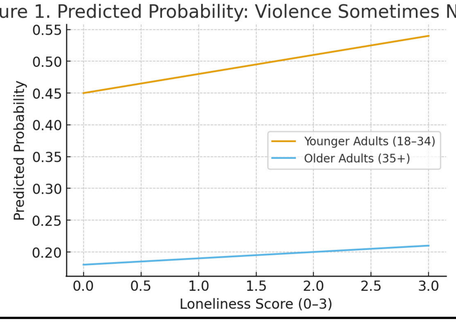


Figure A. Distribution of Loneliness Scores (UCLA 3-Item Scale)

This histogram shows the distribution of loneliness scores among CSAF respondents. Scores range from 0–3, with most individuals clustering around moderate levels of loneliness. This demonstrates sufficient variation to meaningfully test loneliness as a predictor of political violence attitudes.

Intrepretation: Most respondents report moderate levels of loneliness; extreme loneliness is less common but still present.

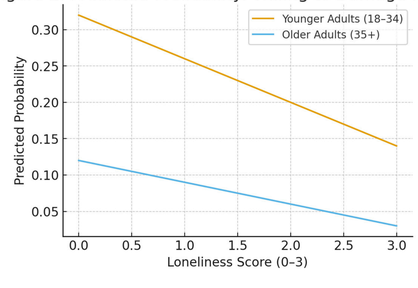
Figure 1. Predicted Probability: Violence Sometimes Necessary



Predicted probabilities from logistic regression show that loneliness does not meaningfully increase support for the belief that political violence is sometimes necessary. However, younger adults consistently show much higher support for political violence than older adults, regardless of loneliness score.

Interpretation: Age—not loneliness—is the key predictor of general acceptance of political violence.

Figure 2. Predicted Probability: Willing to Damage Property



Predicted probabilities indicate that loneliness reduces willingness to engage in property-damaging political actions for both age groups. Younger adults remain more willing than older adults, but loneliness has a consistently negative effect on the likelihood of endorsing destructive political behavior.

Interpretation: Lonely individuals are less willing to engage in destructive political behavior — contradicting assumptions that loneliness drives radicalization.